

GP-49-HI
JUN 1944

RETURN TO
HQ USAFHRC
MAXWELL AFB AL 36112-6678

SCANNED BY ACD
2026

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2006

5423-12

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[REDACTED]

DECLASSIFIED
DOD DIR 5200.2

6249-HI JUN, 1944	RETURN TO RESEARCH STUDIES INSTITUTE U.S.A.F. HISTORICAL DIVISION ARCHIVES BRANCH
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P.R.C.

49th Fighter Group
Jun 1944

SCANNED BY ACD
2006

[REDACTED]

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GP-49-H1-FTR
JUN 44

[REDACTED]

DESIGNATION SHEET

AIR FORCE: Fifth Air Force

COMMAND: Fifth Fighter Command

WING: _____

GROUP: 49th Fighter Group

SQUADRON: _____

PERIOD: June 1944

Has the security classification of
material been checked ? Yes.

P.R.C.

DECLASSIFIED
DOD DIR 5200.2

[REDACTED]

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S E C R E T

RJB/lts

HEADQUARTERS 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCE
APO 920

20 August, 1944.

History for Month of June, 1944Ground Echelon

At 0630 hours on June 1st the 49th Fighter Group Headquarters, 7th, 8th and 9th Fighter Squadrons entrucked and the caravan started the trek to Pie beach. It was with regret that we left our campsite with its beloved bathing facilities. We knew that the water situation at Biak Island was poor.

After a torturous journey of two hours over a road blasted out of the mountain side we arrived at Pie beach. All agreed that the road was much improved compared to the trip a few weeks previous.

Upon arrival at the beach, details were put to work sandbagging the LST ramps and unloading gasoline from them. A delay of about two hours took place while several hundred wounded men, fresh from Biak, were carefully unloaded from an LST. As we stood watching the ambulances and stretchers coming out of the bowels of the ship we began to realize that casualties at Biak were higher than all had been led to believe. Many Javanese and Philipinos were among the group. Some were wounded and others emaciated as a result of Japanese "Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity".

The loading of our equipment was well supervised by designated officers of our Group. The bulk equipment was first placed far back into the hold. Next the mobil loaded equipment was rolled in, some of which was placed up on deck via the ship elevator. After our equipment was stowed in the hold and lashed on deck a few hundred barrels of gasoline were placed in front of the hold. This inflammable fluid had a great influence in enforcing "No Smoking" regulations.

The next day found us lazily floating in the harbor, enjoying good chow and awaiting food rations which Major White was experiencing difficulty in obtaining. After another quiet night in the harbor we lifted anchor and on the 3rd of June the convoy sailed. The short trip to Biak was uneventful with the usual abandon ship drill and "sack" time.

On the 5th of June we bumped against the coral at Bosnek beach. All hands were amazed at the sight which greeted us on the beach. The edge was lined with amphibious vehicles with anti-aircraft guns alerted. A battery of Field Artillery on the beach was methodically lobbing shells over the hills and cliffs toward Jap positions. However, the most disappointing news was that our Infantry were unable to get and keep the airstrip from which we were to operate.

By 1600 all equipment was unloaded and we moved three miles up the beach toward Mokmer drome to a "temporary" campsite. This campsite was an area

ALTA/112

HEADQUARTERS 4TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCE
AND 930

30 August, 1944.

History for Month of June, 1944Ground Section

At 0630 hours on June 1st the 4th Fighter Group Headquarters, 7th, 8th and 9th Fighter Squadrons embarked and the caravan started the trip to the beach. It was with regret that we left our campsite with its beloved bathing facilities. We knew that the water situation at Black Island was poor.

After a tortuous journey of two hours over a road blasted out of the mountain side we arrived at the beach. All agreed that the road was much improved compared to the trip a few weeks previous.

Upon arrival at the beach, details were put to work sandbagging the LST ramps and unloading gasoline from them. A delay of about two hours took place while several hundred wounded men, fresh from Black, were carefully unloaded from an LST. As we stood watching the ambulances and stretchers coming out of the bowels of the ship we began to realize that casualties at Black were higher than all had been led to believe. Many Japanese and Filipino were among the group. Some were wounded and others emaciated as a result of Japanese "Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity".

The loading of our equipment was well supervised by designated officers of our group. The bulk equipment was first placed far back into the hold. Next the mobil loaded equipment was rolled in, some of which was placed up on deck via the ship elevator. After our equipment was stowed in the hold and lashed on deck a few hundred barrels of gasoline were placed in front of the hold. This inflammable fluid had a great influence in enforcing "no smoking" regulations.

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By 1600 all equipment was unloaded and we moved three miles up the beach toward Makmer dome to a "temporary" campsite. This campsite was an area

S E C R E T

49th Ftr Gp Hq Historical Records (June 1944) cont'd.....

estimated at ten thousand (10,000) square yards. Into this sardine can was jammed all vehicles and men. It was late in the evening so hasty shelters were thrown up. Shelter halves and tarps were thrown against the jammed vehicles and equipment. Some men slept under trucks and some in them.

A description of this campsite is necessary in order to appreciate following events*. Strung along either side of the road we were boxed in by swamp, cliffs, Field Artillery and AA units. The battery of 105's barked night and day, their muzzle blast flapping our canvas and eardrums. Up the road a few hundred yards was a much disputed water hole which the Japs counterattacked daily. Mortar fire, fire from rifles and machine guns plus the 105's kept everyone on edge. The first night two red alerts sounded and we witnessed the heaviest flack we had seen in some time.

On the morning of the sixth we received the news which all had sweated for---the invasion of "Festung Europa". Morale perked up and bets were collected. Speculation on the effects of the invasion in regards to our Pacific war ran wild.

However, we also received the news that we still did not have Mokmer so we set about making things more livable in our Dantes Inferno. We dispersed as much as possible and a security patrol was organized against infiltration. Tents and jungle hammocks appeared. It was soon discovered that coral rock is not the ideal stuff in which to dig a trench or plant a victory garden. It was necessary to chip, piece by piece, in order to get below the surface. The heat was terrific and water scarce which added to the discomfort.

Meanwhile red alerts were common every night with heavy AA fire greeting the Nip two or three plane elements. The moon was becoming brighter and fuller each night, reflecting on the coral road which ran through our liebestraum.

On the morning of the 9th a fast Nip plane, reported to be a Tony, buzzed our campsite. Too fast and low for AA fire he must have glimpsed our jam-packed area. That night we were jangled with a shout of "Help, Japs!" in our area. Fearing infiltration we all sweated in our trenches with carbines ready. Three men, Captain K. Smith, 0435105, 1st Lieut. Jacob R. Esser, 0854484, and myself huddled together in a slit trench, tense and trigger happy. Soon we heard something moving through the brush toward us. "It" whispered, "Hey, Joe" repeatedly. This "Hey Joe" is an old Jap trick so Captain Smith leveled his automatic and Lieut. Esser his carbine. The dim figure became outline---Smith tightened his trigger finger and Esser pushed his "safe" button. The figure repeated "Hey Joe, whereinhell's my fartsack?" At this GI lingo we relaxed. The only thing that saved that man's life was the hard pull on Smith's automatic and that Esser pressed his magazine release instead of his "safe". I myself was unarmed. Moral of the story: Don't move around during an alert and use "Hey Joe". Needless to say,

* See attachment #1, Sketch of area.

- 2 -

SECRET

AGTH For Op Mt Historical Records (Jama 1944) cont'd.....

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A description of this campaign is necessary in order to appreciate following events. Strung along either side of the road we were boxed in by swamp, cliffs, Field Artillery and AA units. The battery of 10's parked night and day, their muzzle blast flaring our canvas and equipment. Up the road a few hundred yards was a much disputed water hole which the Japs counterattacked daily. Mortar fire, five from rifles and machine guns plus the 10's kept everyone on edge. The first night two red alerts sounded and we witnessed the heaviest flack we had seen in some time.

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Meanwhile red alerts were common every night with heavy AA fire greeting the hip two or three plane elements. The moon was becoming brighter and fuller each night, reflecting on the coral road which ran through our Lanes.

On the morning of the 9th a fast hip plane, reported to be a Tori, buzzed our campsite. Too fast and low for AA fire he must have glimpsed our jam-packed area. That night we were jangled with a shout of "Help, Japs!" in our area. Fearful infiltration we all sweated in our trenches with carbines ready. Three men, Captain E. Smith, QM5102, 1st Lieut. Jacob E. Esser, Q8248A, and myself huddled together in a slit trench, tense and trigger happy. Soon we heard something moving through the brush toward us. "It" whispered, "Hey, Joe" repeatedly. This "Hey Joe" is an old Jap trick so Captain Smith leveled his automatic and Lieut. Esser his carbine. The dim figure became outline--Smith sighted his trigger finger and Esser pushed his "safe" button. The figure repeated "Hey Joe, whistled" a my "fartach?" At this GI tempo we relaxed. The only thing that saved that man's life was the hand pull on Smith's automatic and that Esser pressed his magazine release instead of his "safe". I myself was warned. Moral of the story: Don't move around during an alert and use "Hey Joe". Needless to say,

* See attachment #1, Sketch of area.

- 2 -

S E C R E T

49th Ftr Gp Hq Historical Records (June 1944) cont'd.....

a lecture was delivered the next day.

On the morning of June 10 we were given a laugh (a bitter one) when we heard a newscast to the effect that Mokmer drome was in our hands and we were ready to operate from it. As far as we knew from infantrymen nearby, the strip was still a disputed article.

On the night of June 11 we went to bed ready for the usual red alerts. We had none the night before so figured a "double feature" was due. Under 2nd Lieut. Quintin K. Rizer's orders many men dispersed into the area evacuated by a battery of artillery.

At 0130 on the morning of June 12 it happened. After a prolonged series of red alerts a stick of six "Daisy Cutters" sliced across our area. In a daze we crawled out of the trucks amid a shower of dirt and debris. A fire blazed at the east end of the road and the acrid smell of powder and hot metal filled the air. The cries of wounded and calls for Medics greeted numbed ears. Under conditions such as this, with an unknown number of casualties, the ambulance wrecked and the whole area a beacons target, a miracle was worked.* At 0155 the first truckload of wounded reached the 92nd Evacuation Hospital about two miles down the rough road.

While the dead were identified and loaded on trucks the search continued for additional casualties. One bomb landing about fifteen (15) yards from Major Alpheus B. White's (O-129788) shack, caught the Major, Lieut. Rizer and 1st Lieut. Arnold L. Hayworth (O-563267) as they ran for shelter. Chaplain Willis L. Stafford (O-475510) in the same shack was blown out of his cot. Only the Chaplain survived, losing a leg and suffering minor injuries.* One bomb landed close to the road, catching Captain William F. Smoots (O-913682) in bed and fatally wounding him. In the same tent 1st Lieut. John K. Glover (O-561101) and Captain Bernard Gurian (O-486669) were blown out of their cots with light wounds. 1st Lieut. Jacob Shelman (O-570212) was the only occupant of this tent taking advantage of a handy slit trench. Hearing the plane and the bombs falling, Shelman stood exposed in his trench, screaming to his tentmates to get to shelter. The blast blew Shelman into the bottom of the trench and Gurian and Glover landed on top of him. Later Shelman found himself with a minor shoulder wound. The same bomb also killed five enlisted men in a nearby tent.

The description of such a catastrophe is not written with but one purpose in mind: That of aiding in analyzing the event. 1st: We had been boxed into an area approximately 200 X 50 yards in size which made dispersal impossible. 2nd: Although camouflage was difficult, at least the vehicle windshields could have been covered to combat reflection of the moon. 3rd: All men who were in slit trenches or underground were uninjured. Last: The "all clear" had not sounded so the men had no business in bed. The natural onset of bitterness should be tempered by the above points.

* See attachment #1, Sketch of area.

* See attachment #2, Commendation.

SECRET

ASST. Dir. Op. Hq. Statistical Records (June 1944) cont'd.....

A lecture was delivered the next day.

On the morning of June 10 we were given a lecture (a bitter one) when we heard a newscast to the effect that Major's plane was in our hands and we were ready to operate from it. As far as we know from intelligence reports, the story was still a disputed article.

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At 0130 on the morning of June 12 it happened. After a prolonged series of red alerts a stick of six "Baby Crushers" allied across our area. In a dense we crawled out of the trenches and a shower of dirt and debris. A fire blazed at the east end of the road and the acrid smell of powder and hot metal filled the air. The cries of wounded and calls for medical aid were heard. Under conditions such as this, with an unknown number of casualties, the ambulance wrecked and the whole area a panicked target, a miracle was worked. At 0155 the first truckload of wounded reached the 2nd Evacuation Hospital about two miles down the road.

While the dead were identified and loaded on trucks the search continued for additional casualties. One bomb landing about fifteen (15) yards from Major Alphaeus R. White's (O-129788) shack, caught the Major, Lieut. Hixon and 1st Lieut. Arnold L. Hayworth (O-563267) as they ran for shelter. Captain Willie L. Stafford (O-475210) in the same shack was blown out of his cot. Only the Captain survived, losing a leg and suffering minor injuries. One bomb landed close to the road, catching Captain William F. Smoots (O-913632) in bed and fatally wounding him. In the same tent 1st Lieut. John K. Glover (O-361101) and Captain Bernard Guntan (O-486662) were blown out of their cots with light wounds. 1st Lieut. Jacob Shelman (O-520212) was the only occupant of this tent taking advantage of a handy slit trench. Hearing the plane and the bombs falling, Shelman stood exposed in his trench, scrambling to his tentmates to get to shelter. The blast blew Shelman into the bottom of the trench and Guntan and Glover landed on top of him. Later Shelman found himself with a minor shoulder wound. The same bomb also killed five enlisted men in a nearby tent.

The description of such a catastrophe is not written with but one purpose in mind: That of aiding in analyzing the event. Last: We had been boxed into an area approximately 200 X 50 yards in size which made dispersal impossible. 2nd: Although camouflage was difficult, at least the vehicle windshield could have been covered to combat reflection of the moon. 3rd: All men who were in slit trenches or underground were injured. Last: The "All clear" had not sounded so the men had no business in bed. The natural onset of bitter-ness should be tempered by the above points.

* See attachment A1, Sketch of area.
* See attachment A2, Commemoration.

- 3 -

S E C R E T

49th Ftr Gp Hq Historical Records (June 1944) cont'd.....

The rest of the morning was devoted to roll calls and cleaning up. One error was immediately recognized. Many of the wounded arrived at the hospital minus dogtags. Thus valuable time was lost while the hospital called us for blood types.

The same morning we again furnished stevedore details to unload IST's filled with gasoline. We were all rather opposed to such work after a night of horror but grudgingly sent the men with two officers in charge. I myself accompanied this detail and soon discovered that this heavy work was an asset in that it enabled the men to work off nervous energy and took their minds off the bombing.

While this unloading was going on the ship's horn sounded an alert. In a few seconds there wasn't a man of the 49th in sight. Natural reflexes and nervousness accounted for this response to a red alert. The Captain of the ship started to chew me, saying the alert was false and to get the men back to work unloading his ship. He was politely informed that the men were naturally jittery as a result of the recent disaster and that the men would be back when an "all clear" sounded. We then stood on the beach and watched two Jap planes get shot down out over the harbor. This was the good sea Captain's "false alert".

The next few days were spent in gathering personal effects of the deceased and supply licking its wounds. Shrapnel had done much damage to vehicles and equipment. Slit trenches were a number one priority during spare moments.

On the 16th of June we received news of the long awaited B-29 raid on Tokyo. As was the case with the European invasion, we all felt elated over the news.

On June 18 under orders from the 308th Bomb Wing we furnished two hundred and fifty (250) men for perimeter defense duty just behind the infantry lines.* The lack of infantry training on the part of the enlisted men caused our officers to worry over this detail. Fortunately, the detail lasted only two days.

On the 18th we received news that Lieut. Colonel David A. Campbell, our commanding officer, was "missing in action". Lieut. Colonel Furlo S. Wagner replaced Campbell as commanding officer of the 49th. Lieut. Colonel George E. Walker also joined the Group at this time. 1st Lieut. Donald A. Johnson and Chaplain Trent joined Group Headquarters on June 18 too.

On the 20th we moved to another temporary campsite about three miles from Mokmer drome which was now in our hands. The ride up the road past the famous cliffs from which occasional mortar and sniping fire still hit the road was accomplished with a well spaced and armed convoy.

* See attachment #4.

- 4 -

SECRET

1944 (June 1944) cont'd.....

The rest of the morning was devoted to roll calls and cleaning up. The error was immediately recognized. Many of the wounded arrived at the hospital minus dogtags. Thus valuable time was lost while the hospital called us for blood types.

The same morning we again furnished stovepots to unload LST's filled with gasoline. We were all rather opposed to such work after a night of horror but grudgingly sent the men with two officers in charge. I myself accompanied this detail and soon discovered that this heavy work was an asset in that it enabled the men to work off nervous energy and took their minds off the bombing.

While this unloading was going on the ship's horn sounded an alarm. In a few seconds there wasn't a man of the LST in sight. Natural reflexes and nervousness accounted for this response to a red alert. The Captain of the ship started to show me, saying the alert was false and to get the men back to work unloading his ship. He was positively informed that the men were naturally jittery as a result of the recent disaster and that the men would be back when an "all clear" sounded. We then stood on the beach and watched two Jap planes get shot down over the harbor. This was the good see Captain's "false alert".

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On the 20th we moved to another temporary campsite about three miles from Wolmer's Grove which was now in our hands. The ride up the road past the famous cliffs from which occasional mortar and artillery fire still hit the road was accompanied with a well spaced and armed convoy.

* See Attachment A.

- A -

SECRET

49th Gp Hq Historical Records (June 1944) cont'd.....

On the 22nd we cheered as the first section of the Air Echelon arrived. The old faithful C-47 was a welcome sight. A couple of Japs paid us another visit on the night of June 25. Three men were injured in the 7th Squadron area by a bomb burst. Apparently we had learned our lesson on dispersal and slit trenches.

The evening of June 27 was one of hilarity. Each man received a bottle of beer with the compliments of Hirohito. Mail arrival also aided morale.

The close of the month found Headquarters ready to move to a new and permanent (?) campsite and the Squadrons already on the move to theirs.

AIR ECHELON ACTIVITIES

Back at Hollandia the 8th Squadron was continuing work on the reconstruction of an Oscar Mk. II Fighter. On June 21st Major Robert V. McHale successfully test flew the plane aptly named the "Raccoon Special".*

Most activity from Hollandia consisted of patrols and bomber cover to Biak. Noemfoor Island received a few dive-bombing and strafing attacks but targets were rather small for dive-bombing. On the 3rd of June the 9th Squadron ran across 15/20 Oscars and Zekes while escorting bombers. The final score was nine Oscars and two Zekes definitely destroyed. On this mission Lieut. Colonel David A. Campbell (O-392746) was reported as missing. Extensive searching went on for the Colonel's plane but nothing was sighted.

A dive-bombing mission on Biak caves highlighted the months activities at Biak. The cave was about two thousand (2000) yards from our camp and everyone had a grandstand seat as the planes pounded the caves, then strafed them. The Squadron commanders of the 7th Squadron and three flight leaders had previously "cased" the caves in L-5's which accounts for accuracy obtained that day.

The month closed with preparations for moving to a final (?) campsite.

Robert J. Boniece

ROBERT J. BONIECE,
1st Lieut., Air Corps,
Historical Officer.

* See Attachment #3 on flight by Mc Hale. Also check 8th Sq for details.

SECRET

1945 Op Hq Historical Records (June 1944) cont'd.....

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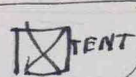
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ROBERT J. BOHNER,
1st Lieut., Air Corps,
Historical Officer.

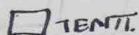
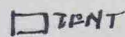
* See Attachment #3 on flight by Mc Hale. Also check 8th Sq for details.

BATHING POOL -

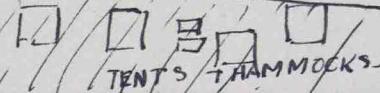
SWAMP.



WOODED HILL.

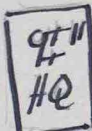


PATH TO POOL.

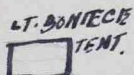


105 ARTILLERY

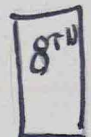
WOODED AREA.



MESS



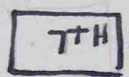
MAJ. WHITES TENT.



MESS



TENTS



MESS

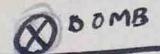
WOODED AREA.



TRUCKS PARKED HERE.



LATRINE

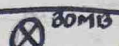


BOSNEK.

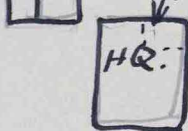
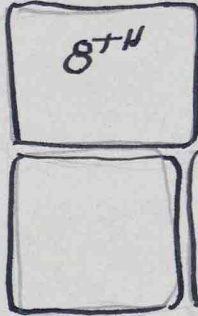
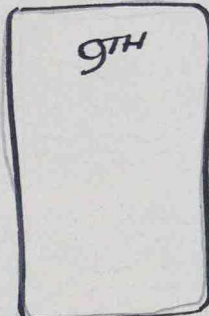
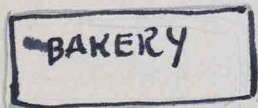


BOMB.

CAPT SMOOTS



ROAD.



OLD GUN PIT



DIRECT HIT



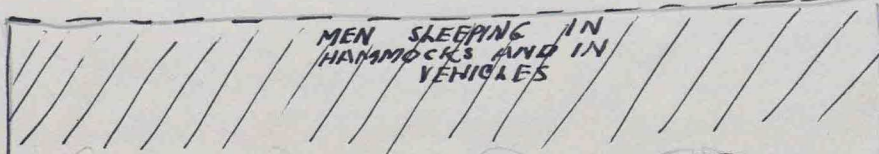
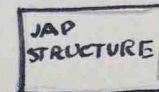
OLD GUN PIT

4 MEN KILLED



BOMB

DRAWN FROM
MEMORY NOT TO SCALE.
BY CAPT. JOHN R. SIERCHOW
HQ.

MEN SLEEPING IN
HAMMOCKS AND IN
VEHICLESJAP
STRUCTURE

WOODED AREA.

* DIED AT HOSPITAL.

(Enclosure # 1.)

HEADQUARTERS 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCES
APO 920

9 July 1944.

To all Officers and Men of the 49th Fighter Group:

No words can fully express the praise, the glory, which each of you has earned beyond a shadow of a doubt since your initial landing on Biak Island.

All of the organization Commanders that I have contacted have praised your willingness and devotion to duty as a meritorious example of coordination and will to do for your country and fellow men.

Your devotion to duty has carried on the high standard by which this Group was formed and as a result you are the bearer of the standard that has made this and previous tactical operations a reality.

My heartiest congratulations.

/s/ Furlo S. Wagner
FURLO S. WAGNER,
Lieutenant Colonel, Air Corps,
Commanding.

A TRUE COPY:

Robert J. Boniece
ROBERT J. BONIECE,
1st Lieut., Air Corps,
Historical Officer.

Attachment 12 (see page 2, true historical record)

HEADQUARTERS
MAY 11 1945
AFC 200

2 July 1944

to all Officers in line of the 1st Division:

No words can fully express the relief, the glow, when each of you has earned beyond a shadow of a doubt since your initial landing on this island.

All of the organization commands that I have contacted have praised your willingness and devotion to duty as a first-class team in of coordination and will look for your coming and follow you.

Your devotion to duty has carried on the day after day which this group has formed and as a result you are the better of the situation that has made this an exciting and successful operation a reality.

My heartfelt congratulations.

Walter A. Brown
Major General, USA
Commanding General, 1st Division

WALTER A. BROWN

WALTER A. BROWN
Major General, USA
Commanding General, 1st Division

HEADQUARTERS 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCES
APO 920

13 August, 1944.

TEST FLIGHT OF OSCAR Mk. II

On 21 June, 1944, I test flew the Nakajima Type 2 Single Seater Fighter (Oscar, Mk. II) that the 8th Fighter Squadron of the 49th Fighter Group had reconstructed out of wrecked planes found at Hollandia, Dutch New Guinea. Work was started on the aircraft on 6 May, 1944 and it was ready to be flown on 21 June, 1944.

I taxied to takeoff position and found the Oscar easy to handle on the ground. The brakes seemed to be satisfactory. I used 38" of Hg and 2500 RPM on takeoff and the aircraft got off the ground after a very short run. The torque was not excessive on takeoff and was very easily held with the rudder which became effective almost as soon as power was applied.

Once in the air the landing gear came up very fast and the aircraft picked up speed rapidly. The climb was good and although there was no rudder trim it didn't require much pressure to hold it straight in either the climb or a dive. All of the controls were easy to operate up to about 300 MPH IAS. At higher speeds the elevators became increasingly stiff and required such pressure to operate them that it would tire one quickly if it were necessary to maneuver at high speeds for any length of time. At lower speeds I found the aircraft extremely maneuverable and it was a pleasure to do aerobatics in it.

The approach to the landing was made at 100 MPH with wheels and flaps down. The landing was a three point one and there was no tendency to ground loop.

It is my opinion that, if the Nip pilots cooperated more and utilized the Oscar's ability to maneuver, they would give us a little more to worry about in fights.

Robert V. McHale
ROBERT V. McHALE,
Major, Air Corps.

Attachment (see page 2, same historical record)

MEMORANDUM FOR THE RECORD
SUBJECT: [illegible]
DATE: [illegible]

12 June 1944

TEST RESULTS OF DROG M. 11

On 21 June 1944, I test flew the Drog M. 11 in the latter (latter, M. 11) of the 3rd Fighter Squadron of the 48th Fighter Group, and recommended one of various planes found at Holloman, New Mexico, and was started on the aircraft on 21 June 1944 and it was ready to go flying on 21 June 1944.

I started to takeoff vertically and found the Drog very easy to handle on the ground. The engine seemed to be satisfactory. I used 25" of Hg and 2500 RPM on takeoff and the aircraft got off the ground after a very short run. The engine was not over-revved on takeoff and was very easily held with the throttle which became effective almost as soon as power was applied.

Once in the air the landing gear came up very fast and the aircraft climbed at a good rate. The climb was good and although there was no underburn in climb, the engine was not over-revved in either the climb or a dive. All of the controls were easy to operate up to about 3000 RPM. At higher speeds the elevator became increasingly stiff and required much pressure to operate than it would at low speeds. It was necessary to maneuver at low speeds for any length of time. At lower speeds I found the aircraft extremely maneuverable and it was a pleasure to be generalist in it.

In approach to the landing we made at 1000 ft. with wheels and flaps down. The landing was a three-point one and there was no tendency to ground loop.

It is my opinion that, if the Drog M. 11 is recommended here and utilized, the Drog's ability to maneuver, they would give us a little more to worry about in 1944.

WALTER V. [illegible]
Major, Air Corps

HEADQUARTERS, 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCES
APO 920

16 August 1944.

DUTY ON THE PERIMETER DEFENSE

On 16 June 1944, the 308th Bomb Wing asked for two hundred and fifty (250) men from the 49th Fighter Group for perimeter defense duty just behind the infantry lines on Biak Island. Inasmuch as I had been acting as Adjutant, at Captain Smith's request, it was my duty to ask for volunteers. With this in mind I called the men together and told them just what had to be done. I told them I would not take married men or men who were on the May rotation list. Those volunteering were S/Sgt. Paul G. Manget, T/Sgt. William C. Wygant Jr., S/Sgt. John H. Anderson, S/Sgt. Antonio Garza, S/Sgt. Harry A. McMahan, S/Sgt. Herman B. Feurstein, Sgt. James C. Honea, Sgt. James E. Kindred, Cpl. Raymond B. Abbott and Pfc Mike Suronovich, all of Group Headquarters. In asking the men to volunteer I felt it no more than right to be the officer to take them on the detail. Before dismissing the volunteers they were given instructions as to what equipment they would take with them.

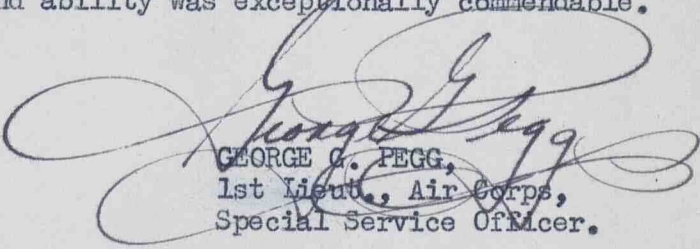
Leaving in trucks early Sunday morning we drove to the end of Bosnik beach where we met an infantry guide who was to lead us over the ridge. Lieut. George E. Webster, 7th Squadron surgeon, asked me to lead the men up the cliff. It was very hot for so early in the morning and the rugged mountain side of coral made the climb even more difficult. We arrived at the first area about forty-five minutes later and I reported to the officer in charge of the unit we were relieving. Leaving seventy-five men at this point I took seventy more and descended the far side of the cliff and walked west about one mile. All along the road was evidence of recent fighting and in the ridges beyond we could hear shell fire from both sides. Again we ascended the cliff and this area was even rougher than the first. We had a large horseshoe like area to defend and my first duty was to disperse the men in two's and three's along the perimeter. After making sure they knew the countersigns, where to walk to evade booby traps, and the necessity of water conservation, I made the rounds again to check the supply of hand grenades. Many men had never seen a grenade before and I used metriculous care in seeing that they would be able to use them without harm to themselves. A grenade thrown at night might hit a tree or limb and be thrown back into our own foxholes. Sleeping was to be done in the foxholes so the men set to work getting ready for nightfall. Captain James D. Kell of the 7th Squadron came up for a few minutes and asked me to go back and take over the first group of men. Before leaving I made arrangements with the Ordnance men to set booby traps at dusk in the most open spaces.

When I returned to the other area I had to repeat the warnings and show the men the use of the grenade. There was to be no smoking or talking above a whisper after dark and carbines were not to be used at night.

I had a C. P. with a field phone and four enlisted men. Our foxhole was about three feet deep and five or six feet across. Banked around it were hundred pound bags of rice which was fermenting and the odor was stifling. After a supper of "J" rations we did the only thing left to do---hit the pad. Each foxhole had a man on guard at all times. The night proved to be a nightmare. Everything was quiet until nearly eleven o'clock when the Japs started to howl like hyenas and firing increased. We had something crawling over us all night long and the rice bags generated such a heat that we lay in perspiration and on the verge of nausea. Noises and moving trees caused the men some anxiety but only a few hand grenades were thrown. In the morning we found the things that had been bothering us all night were---maggots!! It is a wonder we weren't all ill from such filth. We cleaned up some during the day and covered the foxholes with shelter halves. That night some of our booby traps were set off and we used up some thirty grenades. Although no claims were ever voiced, some of us thought we counted two more dead Japs in the ravine than were there the day before.

Things quieted down except for a rumor that we were to be relieved the next day because we were moving into a new camp area. This proved to be true and the next morning I gave the men the order to break camp. Policing was done and roll called as they filed down the path. One fellow couldn't resist the temptation to fire his carbine and I was forced to have him punished with company duty. Again the trip was a long, hot affair and as we arrived in camp some of the trucks were moving out to Mokmer.

The experience had had its unpleasant side but it was a pleasure to me to have had the opportunity to use the infantry training that I had had. Corporal Abbott did a good job and was an inspiration to the men. Most of the men directly under me were from the 8th Fighter Squadron and their willingness, cooperation and ability was exceptionally commendable.



GEORGE C. PEGG,
1st Lieut., Air Corps,
Special Service Officer.

DECLASSIFIED
DOD DIR 5200.9